qadence

Finish the SEO setup: Search Console and a custom domain

Two manual tasks only you can do — they need your Google account, your domain registrar and your GitHub login. Everything else (tags, structured data, sitemap, llms.txt, deploys) is already live.

Part 1 · Google Search Console · ~20 min

Part 2 · Custom domain · optional · ~30 min + DNS wait

Updated 12 November 2026

1 Google Search Console

Proves to Google that you own the site, hands it your sitemap and asks it to index the homepage.

Why you need it: on a GitHub Pages project site, the site lives in a sub-folder (`/qadence/`). Crawlers only look for `robots.txt` at the domain root, so they never see the sitemap link — submitting it here fixes that.

2 Custom domain optional

Moves the site to your own address, e.g. `www.qadence.dev`. Costs a yearly domain fee; GitHub Pages hosting stays free.

What you gain: `robots.txt` and `llms.txt` sit at the domain root where search engines and AI crawlers look automatically, a short memorable URL, and a full "Domain" property in Search Console.

? **Which order?** If you plan to buy a domain in the next few weeks, do **Part 2 first**, then follow Part 1 with the new domain (step 8 of Part 2 tells you how) — so you only verify once. Otherwise do **Part 1 now**; it keeps working, and you add the new domain later.

Your site at a glance

Live site	https://tayabghafor.github.io/qadence/
Sitemap	https://tayabghafor.github.io/qadence/sitemap.xml
Repository	https://github.com/TayabGhafor/qadence (GitHub account **TayabGhafor**)
Deploy status	https://github.com/TayabGhafor/qadence/actions — every push to `main` deploys in about a minute
Folder that is published	`dist/` inside the project folder `sqa-interview-practice`

Before you start

- A Google account you will keep using (Search Console access is tied to it).
- The project folder on this computer and a terminal — or Claude Code, which can do the file and git steps for you.
- For Part 2: a domain (or the budget to buy one) and the login for its DNS settings.

1 Google Search Console

~20 minutes · free · Indexing itself then takes a few days to a couple of weeks.

1 Add your site as a "URL prefix" property

1. Open search.google.com/search-console and sign in.
2. Open the property menu at the top left and choose **Add property**.
3. Use the **right-hand box, URL prefix** — not "Domain". (A Domain property needs DNS records, and you can't add those to `github.io`.)
4. Type the address exactly, with the trailing slash: `https://tayabghafor.github.io/qadence/` → **Continue**.

2 Download the HTML verification file

1. On the verification screen pick **HTML file** (usually the recommended method).
2. Click the download button. You get a file named like `google1a2b3c4d5e6f7g8h.html`.
3. **Do not rename or edit it.** Leave this browser tab open — you will come back to click Verify.

3 Put the file in `dist/` and push it

Copy the downloaded file into the `dist` folder of the project (next to `index.html`), then run:

```
# go to the project folder
cd ~/"Documents/My DATA/QA-site/sqa-interview-practice"
# commit and publish the verification file
git add dist/google*.html
git commit -m "Add Google Search Console verification file"
git push
```

✓ **Easier:** in Claude Code, say *"Add this Search Console verification file to dist and push it"* and give it the file's path.

4 Wait for the deploy, then open the file in your browser

1. Open the Actions page and wait for the newest **Deploy to GitHub Pages** run to show a green check (about a minute).
2. In a private/incognito window open `https://tayabghafor.github.io/qadence/` + your file name, e.g. `…/qadence/google1a2b3c4d5e6f7g8h.html`.
3. Make sure this address is exactly the one the Search Console screen asks for.

You should see one line: **google-site-verification: google1a2b3c4d5e6f7g8h.html**

5 Click Verify

Go back to the Search Console tab and click **Verify**. Expected: **Ownership verified** → **Go to property**.

! **Never delete this file from `dist/`.** Google re-checks it from time to time; if it disappears you lose access to the property after a grace period.

6 Submit the sitemap

1. In the left menu open **Indexing** → **Sitemaps**.
2. In **Add a new sitemap** the box already shows `https://tayabghafor.github.io/qadence/` — type `sitemap.xml` after it and click **Submit**.

Status should become **Success**. "Couldn't fetch" or "Pending" right after submitting is common for new sites — check again in a few hours.

---

7 Ask Google to index the homepage

1. Paste `https://tayabghafor.github.io/qadence/` into the search bar at the top (**Inspect any URL**) and press Enter.
2. "URL is not on Google" is normal for a new site. Click **Request indexing** and wait for "Indexing requested".

---

8 Check back in a week

- **Indexing → Pages** shows when the homepage is indexed; **Performance** shows search queries and clicks after that.
- **Only one page will be indexed — that's expected.** The app screens use `#/…` addresses, which Google treats as the same page. The landing page, its FAQ and structured data carry the SEO.

+ **Bonus (5 minutes): Bing Webmaster Tools.** Bing's index also feeds Microsoft Copilot and other AI search tools. Open bing.com/webmasters, sign in, choose **Import from Google Search Console**, pick the Qadence property and import — the verification and sitemap come with it.

Part 1 checklist

- [ ] URL-prefix property added with the trailing slash
- [ ] Verification file pushed to `dist/` and opens in the browser
- [ ] "Ownership verified" shown
- [ ] Sitemap submitted, status Success
- [ ] Homepage indexing requested
- [ ] (Optional) Imported into Bing Webmaster Tools

2 Custom domain optional

~30 minutes | domain fee yearly | DNS changes can take up to 24 hours.

In the examples, replace `example.com` / `www.example.com` with your real domain.

1 Choose and buy a domain

- Buy it from any registrar (for example Cloudflare Registrar, Namecheap or Porkbun) — GitHub doesn't sell domains.
- Decide the address visitors will use: **www + the bare domain** (`www.example.com` and `example.com`) or a **subdomain** of a domain you already own (`learn.example.com`). Both work; www/subdomain is the simplest.

2 Verify the domain with GitHub first (protects it from takeover)

1. On GitHub click your profile picture → **Settings** (your **account** settings, not the repository).
2. In the sidebar under **Code, planning, and automation** click **Pages** → **Add a domain**.
3. Enter the bare domain (`example.com`) → **Add domain**. GitHub shows a TXT record.
4. At your registrar's DNS settings add it — type **TXT**, host `_github-pages-challenge-TayabGhafor` (most registrars add `.example.com` for you), value copied from GitHub.
5. Wait a few minutes, then click **Verify**. If you left the page: Pages settings → **…** next to the domain → **Continue verifying**.

Keep this TXT record forever — it keeps the domain verified.

3 Add the domain to the repository

1. Open github.com/TayabGhafor/qadence → Settings → Pages.
2. Under **Custom domain** enter the address visitors will use (e.g. `www.example.com`) → **Save**.

> i No `CNAME` file is needed in the project: Qadence deploys with GitHub Actions, and GitHub ignores that file for Actions deployments.

4 Create the DNS records at your registrar

For www or a subdomain — one CNAME record (note: no `/qadence`):

TYPE	HOST / NAME	VALUE / TARGET
CNAME	`www (or learn)`	`tayabghafor.github.io`

For the bare domain (`example.com`) — four A and four AAAA records, host `@`:

TYPE	HOST	VALUES (ONE RECORD EACH)
A	`@`	`185.199.108.153` · `185.199.109.153` · `185.199.110.153` · `185.199.111.153`
AAAA	`@`	`2606:50c0:8000::153` · `2606:50c0:8001::153` · `2606:50c0:8002::153` · `2606:50c0:8003::153`

- Delete the registrar's default "parking" records for `@` and `www` so they don't conflict.
- Set up both the bare domain and `www` if you can — GitHub then redirects one to the other automatically.
- Don't create wildcard records (`*.example.com`) — they let others claim your subdomains.

5 Wait for the DNS check, then turn on HTTPS

1. Back in **Settings → Pages**, wait until it says **DNS check successful** (minutes, up to 24 hours).
2. Tick **Enforce HTTPS**. If it's greyed out, the certificate isn't ready yet — it can take up to 24 hours.

```
# optional check from a terminal — should show tayabghafor.github.io and/or 185.199.x.153
dig www.example.com +short
```

6 Point the project's SEO at the new address

The canonical URL, social cards, structured data, sitemap, robots.txt, llms.txt and 404 page all come from one setting. Change it and regenerate:

1. In `tools/build-seo.js` (line 24) set `const SITE_URL = 'https://www.example.com/';` — keep the trailing slash.
2. Change the "Live site" line in `README.md` and `dist/README.md`.

```
cd ~/"Documents/My DATA/QA-site/sqa-interview-practice"
node tools/build-seo.js                  # rewrites the generated SEO files
git add -A
git commit -m "Move Qadence to www.example.com"
git push
gh repo edit TayabGhafor/qadence --homepage https://www.example.com/
```

✓ **Easier:** tell Claude Code *"Switch Qadence to https://www.example.com/"*. The deploy check fails on purpose if this step is skipped, so the site can't go out with the old address in its tags.

7 Test the new address

- Open `https://www.example.com/`, then `/robots.txt`, `/sitemap.xml` and `/llms.txt` — all should load.
- A made-up path (e.g. `/abc`) shows the Qadence 404 page with a working "Go to Qadence" button.
- The old `https://tayabghafor.github.io/qadence/` now redirects to the new domain.

8 Tell Google (and Bing) about the new domain

1. Search Console → **Add property** → left-hand box **Domain** → `example.com` → copy the TXT record → add it at your registrar → **Verify**. This covers http, https, www and every subdomain.
2. **Indexing → Sitemaps** → submit `https://www.example.com/sitemap.xml`.
3. **URL inspection** → new homepage → **Request indexing**.
4. Keep the old github.io property and its verification file; it will simply show the redirect. If you use Bing Webmaster Tools, add the new site there too.

Part 2 checklist

- [ ] Domain bought
- [ ] Domain verified in GitHub account settings (TXT kept)
- [ ] Custom domain saved in repo Settings → Pages
- [ ] CNAME / A / AAAA records created, parking records removed
- [ ] DNS check successful, Enforce HTTPS ticked
- [ ] SITE_URL changed, build-seo run, pushed
- [ ] New address, robots.txt, sitemap, llms.txt load
- [ ] Domain property verified, sitemap submitted

Troubleshooting

WHAT YOU SEE	WHAT TO DO
Search Console says the verification file wasn't found	Check the deploy finished (green check on the Actions page), the file is in `dist/` (not the project root), the name is unchanged, and it opens in a private window at the exact address the wizard shows. Then click Verify again.
`git push` **is rejected or asks for a login**	Run `gh auth status` — the active account must be **TayabGhafor**. Switch with `gh auth switch --user TayabGhafor`, then push again.
The deploy run is red	Open the run on the Actions page. "Run 'node tools/build-seo.js' and commit the result" means the generated SEO files are out of date — run that command, commit, push.
Sitemap status "Couldn't fetch"	Usual for brand-new properties. Confirm the sitemap URL opens in a browser, wait a few hours, then remove and resubmit it.
Still not on Google after a few days	Normal for new sites — indexing can take a couple of weeks. Request indexing once; repeating it doesn't speed things up. Links from your GitHub profile, LinkedIn or a blog help Google find the site sooner.
GitHub Pages: "DNS check unsuccessful" or "improperly configured"	DNS can take up to 24 hours. Check with `dig`; remove conflicting parking records; make sure the CNAME points to `tayabghafor.github.io` with no path.
"Enforce HTTPS" stays greyed out	Wait up to 24 hours after the DNS check passes. If your DNS has CAA records, one must allow `letsencrypt.org`.
The site shows a 404 on the new domain	Re-enter the domain in repo Settings → Pages and save, then re-run the latest deploy from the Actions page (**Re-run all jobs**).

Quick reference

Search Console	search.google.com/search-console
Bing Webmaster	bing.com/webmasters
Repo Pages settings	github.com/TayabGhafor/qadence/settings/pages
Account Pages (verify domain)	github.com/settings/pages
GitHub's custom-domain docs	docs.github.com → Pages → Configuring a custom domain
Regenerate SEO files	`node tools/build-seo.js` (check only: `--check`)